Boavista Golf

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BDT 2004 · Lagos · Featuring Paddy, Knoxy, Charlie & Langrish

Written for the 2026 countdown to BDT 2026 in Scottsdale

Next up is a golfing story. The standard of golf on tour has undoubtedly improved over the years; the stats demonstrate this not only with generally lower handicaps all round but with the stableford point scores now much higher year on year than they used to be. There was a time when 95 stableford points over your three rounds would pretty much guarantee you a top 3 finish whereas on BDT 2025 12 Dogs reached 100 points! But back in the early days of tour, some truly shocking golf was on display and so the question that comes to mind is: "What is the worst round of golf ever played on tour?!".



Boavista GC

On an individual basis, there have been three single-figure scores – Ravo's 8-pointer in the infamous "Bite & Swipe" round on BDT 2011 and Robbo's 9-pointer on BDT 2003 among them; but we all know that Hursty's 4-pointer on BDT 2008 represents the worst individual round – so far!

In terms of fourballs, however, there are a few contenders, with that "Bite & Swipe" round on BDT 2011 surely right up there. But (with apologies in advance to my fellow players) this writer's view of the worst fourball round ever played dates back to BDT 2004 and, sadly, was one I participated in. Towards the end of that tour, which back in those days was a seven-day endurance test, the Dogs took on Boavista in Portugal. Prior to the round we had been informed that it was a very challenging track at the best of times; as we arrived with high winds and rainstorms that day, it was playing tough to say the least!

At the clubhouse beforehand most of the lads plumped for buggies but for some unknown reason the final group of Charlie, Langrish, Knoxy and myself decided that we fancied the walk – serious error! It was comfortably the least enjoyable round of golf I have ever played, with 200-yard tee shots required into the wind just to clear 50-foot deep ravines! I recollect that on one hole all four of us were playing five off the tee!

It's fair to say that none of the four of us brought our A-game and it would be no surprise to me if, collectively, we neared 500 shots between us. Maybe only on the Jim McLean course in Florida have more balls been lost during a single round! Holes were regularly won with 7s and halved in 8s and 9s!

We returned to the Boavista clubhouse bedraggled and soaked from the incessant rain, weather-beaten by gale force winds, exhausted from constant ball-hunting without buggies to aid us and generally very grumpy!

Thankfully we are all slightly better golfers these days and, as to whether we should hire buggies, the question is not even asked (so long as they are allowed on the fairways)!

A description of just one hole from that round was provided after tour by Langrish, which gives a feel for the quality of golf on display:



LANGRISH

"I'm not sure which hole we were on but it was the one after the par 3 over the Portuguese Grand Canyon. I hit my tee shot ok but the wind caught it and took it left to the fringe of the rough. Not great, but the way things had been going I was pleased with this result; that is, until I got to the ball.

The ball had rolled on and was nestled in thick rough sitting under some pretty arid scrub bush. "No problem", I thought, I will lay out to the fairway and play my third. Simple really, however, as we all know it does not always go to plan.

I fought my way into the scrub and took up a pretty uncomfortable stance. Ran through a few practice swings, my back swing was approximately 24 inches and my follow through was pretty aggressive due to the springy nature of the bush behind me. Gud.

Here goes...shot one... freshy... Gud! Regroup.

Here goes...shot two... freshy... Gud!! Regroup.

Here goes... Shot three... freshy... Gud!!!

For the record, shot four made contact and scuffed out to the fairway. Shot 5 I hit a good shot, unfortunately too good, the ball flew over the back of the hole OB. Blob. Good times."

Charlie's take on the same round is as follows:



CHARLIE

"The Captains had decided to throw the tour hackers in together for the final pairings...just as well in hindsight if the first tee shots were anything to go by. Visual on first tee - line of gleaming villas to the right, way out of range bar a horrendous slice, open fairway, and Hurricane Derek guiding us on our way.

What followed was the worst collective set of tee shots seen on tour. Langrish first up - launches first shot into villas, ugly, ugly slice. Reload, Sally's it down the fairway.

Next up me - first tee shot into same villa Langrish had just gone into. Second tee shot, even worse slice into their neighbour's garden. Third shot, villas again. Fack it, long round ahead.

Once the Retrievers had calmed down from seeing the Bloodhounds show off their repertoires, the villas to the right promptly found themselves with 4 more little visitors and probably a decent repair bill as well.

I think Paddy and Langrish halved the hole with a pair of 9's. Globetopper and Sultan, a couple of respectable opening blobs.

Impressive start to one bloody tough round, dominated by Hurricane Derek. Bloodhounds get the point needed, somehow."

The Bloodhounds went on to secure the Ryder Cup that year, the very first one ever held. None of us needs any reminder that following 21 further editions the scores are 11-11 going into Scottsdale!

SINCE SCOTTSDALE

After Scottsdale the Retrievers lead the Ryder Cup 12–11.